

# Ibn Khaldun & The Year 1892: A Student Study Guide

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*“The past resembles the future more than one drop of water resembles another.” — **Ibn Khaldun**, *The Muqaddimah* (1377 CE)*

This study guide explores the revolutionary theories of Ibn Khaldun, the 14th-century scholar who founded the sciences of sociology and history. We apply his “lenses” to the pivotal year of 1892 to see how civilizations rise, peak, and eventually fall.

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## Who Was Ibn Khaldun?

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Imagine a young man who witnessed the collapse of governments, devastating wars, and the horrors of the Black Death—which claimed both his parents when he was just 17. Instead of despairing, **Ibn Khaldun** (1332–1406 CE) asked a fundamental question: **Why does this keep happening?**

Born in Tunis, North Africa, he spent his life studying power. In 1377, he spent five months in an Algerian castle writing *The Muqaddimah* (“The Introduction”), a book that established the rules for how human civilizations function.

## The Big Question

*“Why do powerful empires always fall apart... and what causes new ones to rise from the ruins?”*

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## The Big Ideas of the Muqaddimah

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Ibn Khaldun didn’t just record dates; he looked for the **laws** of history.

| Concept                       | Description                                                                                             |
|-------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>The Empirical Method</b>   | Don't just believe stories; look for evidence and ask if the story makes sense based on human behavior. |
| <b>Sociological Causation</b> | History is driven by groups of people, not just individual "heroes."                                    |
| <b>Cyclical Theory</b>        | History moves in repeating patterns. Groups rise, peak, rot, and fall.                                  |
| <b>Proto-Economics</b>        | He understood that high taxes and unfair wages destroy economies 400 years before modern economists.    |
| <b>Philosophy of History</b>  | History is a science with deeper laws beneath the surface.                                              |



## Asabiyyah: The Superpower of Groups

**Asabiyyah** (Ah-SAH-bee-yah) is the most important term in Khaldunian theory. It refers to **group loyalty**, "team spirit," or the social glue that holds a civilization together.

- **Strong Asabiyyah:** A sports team that trusts each other completely; early American colonists united against the British.
- **Weak Asabiyyah:** A company where workers feel cheated; a team where players hate each other.

### The Asabiyyah Rule

***Hard Times** → Strong group bond → Power to rise **Easy Times** → Weak group bond → Vulnerability to fall*



## The Rise & Fall Cycle (The 5 Stages)

Ibn Khaldun observed that most dynasties or empires last about **three generations** (roughly 120 years) and pass through five distinct stages:

1. **The Rise (The Struggle):** A tough group with strong *asabiyyah* takes power.

2. **The Building (The Growth):** The new rulers build cities, laws, and monuments.
  3. **The Peak (The Luxury):** Life becomes comfortable. People focus on art, food, and wealth.
  4. **The Rotting (The Decay):** Rulers become greedy and lazy. They raise taxes to pay for their luxury.
  5. **The Collapse (The End):** The group bond is gone. A new, tougher group arrives and takes over.
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## Desert vs. City (Badawa vs. Hadara)

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Ibn Khaldun compared two types of people:

- **Badawa (Nomads/Desert People):** They live in harsh conditions, which makes them brave, tough, and deeply loyal to one another (Strong Asabiyyah).
  - **Hadara (City People):** They live in comfort and culture. While they are more “civilized,” they become soft and lose their group bond (Weak Asabiyyah).
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## Economics: Who Gets the Money?

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Ibn Khaldun argued that **labor** is the source of all wealth.

- **The Incentive Rule:** If you tax people too much, they stop working hard because they can’t keep what they earn.
  - **The Value Rule:** When rulers take too much money from the people to pay for their own luxury, the whole economy eventually breaks down.
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## The 5 Lenses: Reading 1892 Like Ibn Khaldun

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The year 1892 provides a perfect laboratory to test these theories.

## 1. The Homestead Strike (USA)

Andrew Carnegie made record profits but cut worker wages.

- **Khaldunian View:** Carnegie was destroying the *asabiyyah* of his own workforce. When workers are treated as “resources” rather than partners, the group bond breaks, leading to conflict.

## 2. The Hamburg vs. Altona Cholera Outbreak

Hamburg (rich, poorly led) was devastated; Altona (well-led) was safe.

- **Khaldunian View:** Leadership is the “form” and society is the “matter.” Bad leadership in Stage  $\frac{4}{5}$  empires fails to protect the people even from basic threats.

## 3. The British Empire in India

Britain was extracting £30-40 million a year from India.

- **Khaldunian View:** This is classic Stage 4 extraction. By draining the people's wealth, the empire was ensuring its own future collapse by fueling Indian resentment and destroying the local economy.

## 4. The Rise of Japan

Japan was rapidly industrializing and building a new national identity.

- **Khaldunian View:** Japan was creating **Synthetic Asabiyyah**—not based on old tribes, but on a shared national mission. This new energy allowed them to rise while older empires (like the Qing Dynasty) were falling.

## 5. The Populist Movement

Farmers and workers united against banks and monopolies.

- **Khaldunian View:** This was a “Stage 1” seed. A new group was forming with strong bonds, born out of the hardship of the industrial era.
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## Vocabulary: Words to Know

| Word              | Pronunciation  | Definition                                                                               |
|-------------------|----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Muqaddimah</b> | moo-KAD-ee-mah | “Introduction” in Arabic; the title of Ibn Khaldun’s masterpiece.                        |
| <b>Asabiyyah</b>  | ah-SAH-bee-yah | Group loyalty and social solidarity.                                                     |
| <b>Badawa</b>     | BAH-dah-wah    | Nomadic or desert people; possessors of strong asabiyyah.                                |
| <b>Hadara</b>     | HAH-dah-rah    | Settled city people; cultured but often with weakening bonds.                            |
| <b>Empirical</b>  | em-PEER-ih-kul | Based on observation and evidence rather than hearsay.                                   |
| <b>Synthetic</b>  | sin-THET-ik    | Created or man-made; used here to describe national identity as a new form of asabiyyah. |



## Check Your Understanding

### Recall Questions

1. Where was Ibn Khaldun born, and what major event happened when he was 17?
2. What does “asabiyyah” mean, and why is it the “superpower” of groups?
3. List the five stages of the rise and fall cycle.

### Think Deeper

1. Why do “hard times” create stronger bonds than “easy times”? Do you agree with Ibn Khaldun?
2. Looking at the world today, can you identify a group with strong *asabiyyah*?
3. Which stage of the cycle (1–5) do you think your country is in right now? Why?